relations with East Germany until the 1970s. Independent India's defence equipment was initially sourced more from Britain and West Germany (which licensed Dornier aircraft production to India and whose engineers helped India develop its first indigenous combat aircraft, the HF-24 Marut). [40] Despite the colonial experience and the justifiable consternation about Britain's support for Pakistani positions at the United Nations, India also opted to remain a part of the Commonwealth. This enabled India to become a major beneficiary of funds from the Colombo Plan established by the Commonwealth after 1950. This programme helped accelerate investments in agricultural production, medical sciences, urban planning, and technological development. [41]

It was only in the mid-1950s onwards that India began to establish economic and technological relations with the Soviet bloc. Economically, the opportunities for collaboration with the Soviet Union increased after the death of Joseph Stalin in 1953. Until that time, Soviet leaders in Moscow had shunned Indian diplomats, but they began meeting the Indian ambassador to Moscow S. Radhakrishnan, later India's vice president and president. Soviet propaganda efforts in India became less forceful. In 1955, new Soviet leader Nikita Khrushchev signed an agreement with India to provide economic and technical assistance for a major steel plant in Bhilai in central India. This was the first major example of Soviet economic and technical assistance outside the avowedly communist countries, and it was swiftly accompanied by other projects. That year, Khrushchev and Soviet Premier Nikolai Bulganin made a triumphal visit to India, where they were greeted warmly. Along with Nehru's visit to the Soviet Union, these signals reaffirmed Moscow's commitment to 'co-existence' with non-communist countries. The material consequences of this rapprochement were immediately apparent: Indo–Soviet trade tripled between 1956 and 1959. In 1957, the USSR vetoed a resolution on Jammu and Kashmir that the United States and the United Kingdom had supported, which would have disadvantaged India. India also started sourcing defence equipment from the Soviet bloc, initially transport aircraft, such as An-12 in 1960. In the